

Dallas Baptist University

The Throne, the Lamb & the Dragon: A Reader's Guide to the Book of Revelation

A Book Review Submitted to

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New Testament Literature and Interpretation

Graduate School of Ministry

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Bibliographical Entry

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Annotation

To worship God is to follow the Lamb into the great redemptive war, even unto death, a place where the Lamb has gone and promised the glory of resurrection. Who deserves our worship? What does it mean to follow the Lamb wherever it goes? What constitutes true victory? The author addresses all these questions with a challenging perspective on the book of Revelation.

About The Author

Dr. Paul Spilsbury is a distinguished scholar of New Testament studies and early Christian history. He currently serves as the academic dean and professor of New Testament at Regent College in Vancouver. Highly prepared, he has established himself as an authority in Jewish and early Christian literature, concentrating on the Apostle Paul, the Book of Revelation, and ancient apocalyptic literature.

One of Dr. Spilsbury's major contributions to historical literature is found in the dissertation, *The Image of the Jew in Flavius Josephus' Paraphrase of the Bible* (1998), along with the collaboration in translating the multi-volume series *Flavius Josephus, Translation and Commentary*.

Beyond the classroom, Dr. Spilsbury frequently speaks at churches, bridging ancient texts with contemporary Christian life. As for personal interests, the author is also a juried member of the Federation of Canadian Artists, primarily working in watercolors.

This fascinating blend of art and profound historical passion gives the author a unique perspective on the Book of Revelation. It intertwines Old Testament and apocalyptic literature elements with rich symbolic imagery that resonates with daily Christian life.

Summary of Concepts

“The big picture”

The book *The Throne, The Lamb, and The Dragon* presents a non-literal interpretation of Revelation as a call to worship God by following Jesus, the Lamb of God, embracing suffering and sacrifice as means of achieving victory through defeat in the great war against evil until the New Jerusalem descends from heaven.

The key to understanding Revelation

The author presents the book of Revelation as a letter about God, Jesus, and the terrible conflict of good vs evil (12). After introducing itself as a letter, its main body is written as an apocalypse, a dramatic, non-linear, non-literal, symbol-filled story designed to provoke a response from the reader (43). Providing the key to the symbolic meaning is crucial for the reader. The book aims to supply this key, presenting it as a reader’s guide to Revelation.

A letter: Personal, Historic Intention (22)

As the author argues, a letter should be understood in its own historical setting and based on the intent of the original audience. This letter's main intent is to call the original audience to contemplate the throne (to worship God) and follow Jesus’s way of sacrifice (the lamb). It calls the church to persevere by following the lamb into a battle with evil (the dragon) that guarantees death, as it is in defeat that the lamb achieves the final victory, the new Jerusalem.

The hermeneutical outline proposed reflects the approach given. The main message is condensed in the first three chapters of Revelation, addressed directly to the church. The body in

chapters 4-22, which contains the *apocalypse*, is an expanse of the first four chapters (43). The last two chapters, 21 and 22, remind the original reader of why to endure: A living hope, Jesus coming back and establishing the new heavens and the new earth (50).

An apocalypse: dramatic, symbol-filled story (28)

Spilsbury defines an apocalypse as a “heavenly revelation of some kind” (29) delivered in a highly symbolic, non-linear, non-literal story intended to create an imaginary universe using Old Testament symbols and symbolic numbers (32).

The author provides three levels of understanding of the non-linear structure (47). Level one: The throne scene. Level 2: Events that flow from the throne scene. Level 3: Details from the events flowing from the throne scene (48).

Hermeneutical tools for symbolic reading

The author provides two hermeneutical tools for Revelation's highly symbolic, non-literal meaning: Old Testament echoes and numeric symbolism. By understanding what the image represents in the Old Testament, the reader should extrapolate and apply symbolically to Revelation. In the same way, the author argues that numbers are not literal but carry a symbolic meaning, defining the true meaning behind the text (31).

The idea of the symbolic meaning of images and numbers gives the author its main argument for a purely symbolic reading of Revelation's *apocalypse* portion. Both tools are used throughout the book's main body to describe the images, numbers, and events that represent the daily and temporal battle between the Lamb, the saints, and the evil forces of the world led by the dragon.

A response: Discipleship

While it may be easy to get lost in the trenches of symbols and structures, the author intends the reader to react to Revelation as a call to “follow the slaughtered lamb wherever it goes” (38). This provides the biggest insight into how to read Revelation. Understanding that the main goal of the “imaginary universe” is to change the readers' lives forever, provoking them to worship God and follow the lamb even unto death.

It is a call to the original reader, a call to the historic reader, and a call to the present-day reader. A discipleship of bearing witness to God, a discipleship of resistance, a discipleship of personal participation. “Revelation gives us the ‘big picture’ of God’s plan for the world and challenges us to live now in light of God’s claims over the universe” (3).

The Throne, The Lamb, and The Dragon.

The rest of the book follows through Revelation, providing the keys to understanding the symbolic meaning of each element of the *apocalypse* portion.

The throne room

The throne room is a call to behold and worship God, the One seated on the throne, the ruler of the world. The author explains that revelation puts the throne room at the center and recalls Old Testament parallels, such as thunder and lightning in Mt. Sinai, to remind the reader of Who is the One Seated at the throne. The crystal sea contrasts with the earthly sea, which is used as a symbol of chaotic and evil forces.

Then, the focus shifts to the response in worship of the “priestly people of God,” represented by the twenty-four elders, and the whole cosmos, represented by the living creatures. The words used to describe God are intended to recall Old Testament descriptions and thus point to the same God.

The lamb

To worship God is to follow the lamb wherever He goes. (67) In a highly symbolic scene, the lamb is introduced as the only one worthy of opening a scroll, thus making the lamb the kingdom's heir. The use of messianic language to describe the lamb intends to clarify He is indeed the Messiah. At the same time, the image of a lamb intends to draw from the exodus scene, describing why he is worthy (69).

The great war

Revelation depicts a battle between two lords, the Lamb and the Dragon. There exists a kingdom with a true heir, the Lamb, but a usurper, the Dragon, emerges. The Dragon remains in constant conflict with the woman, representing the community of believers. As Spilsbury explains, this great war resembles an ancient folktale that employs symbols from the Old Testament to highlight the contrast between those who worship Satan and those who endure and persevere by worshipping God, following the slaughtered Lamb into “mortal combat with a ferocious enemy” (107).

The followers of the lamb

The symbolic war is key to uncovering the meaning of the 144,000 and the two witnesses as symbols representing those who follow the Lamb and their role in this era (73). Presenting numeric symbolism, the author outlines the different periods of time that indicate a 3.5-year tribulation, representing the “great ordeal” that the followers of the Lamb will endure in this time: to follow the Lamb even unto death (83). Worshipping God is a call to die. The victory of this war between good and evil comes through defeat, by not loving one’s life even unto death.

The followers of the Dragon

The dragon intends to devour the child of the woman (the lamb). When the dragon fails, he turns into “the rest of his children” (the followers of the lamb) (91). Those who worship the dragon

are lured by “the beast” and “the other beast.” This refers to Rome, the historical empire in power, as well as the state-mandated worship of the state. Just as the 144,000 were marked, these followers of Satan are marked by the beast, with both marks symbolizing loyalty and belonging (99). The final image, the great whore, employs the actual cities of Rome and Babylon to illustrate the dangers of idolatry and spiritual unfaithfulness to The One seated on the throne. This contrasting analogy concludes by emphasizing the victory of those who did not worship the dragon and remained faithful to God until death.

The wrath to come

Revelation takes the biblical idea of righteousness and sin to remind its readers that God will not tolerate the affront of sin and evil forever. The author presents the events as “symbolic of the presence of God’s anger in the world even now” (114). These events echo the Old Testament. From Exodus, it draws imagery of heavy earthquakes and plagues (117). From Jeremiah, it brings in the burnt-out mountain called Wormwood. From Isaiah, we have the host of heaven. The author explains that Revelation employs this as a theme and motif in a way that should be understood symbolically rather than literally, illustrating the wrath that comes to all who oppose God. For example, the final battle is a call to be prepared at all times, drawing from Isaiah and Jeremiah “deliberately mixing metaphors” to give us a “message against human arrogance and godlessness” (125).

Hope for endurance

The author notes that at the end of the revelation, there is a sudden change from a lamb to a warrior mounting a white horse coming to a great battle, which, according to the author, is not to be taken as a literal battle but as a metaphor of the defeat of Christ enemies. Again, It is a literary

mechanism that contrasts the fate of those who worship the lamb against those who worship the dragon.

The slaughtered lamb returns as the resurrected warrior. The life of those who follow the slaughtered lamb is rooted in the hope of the resurrected lamb. It is a life of faith that endures sacrifice today in view of the resurrection to come. “It is empowered in the here and now by the presence of God’s Spirit. But oriented toward the future that still awaits us.” (131)

The new Jerusalem

According to the author, those who worship the lamb will be received in the New Jerusalem as the bride of the lamb (143). These two final images represent the final hope. The bride of the lamb points to God’s covenantal faithfulness, while the New Jerusalem speaks about the eternal dwelling place of those who follow the lamb and the eternal presence of God finally dwelling with them.

Critical Evaluation

As a reader’s guide, the book aims to give the reader a big-picture approach to understanding Revelation. Dr. Spilsbury accomplishes this task. Nevertheless, to do so in such a narrow book, the big picture reflects his own viewpoints and biases. It lacks a proper presentation of other plausible interpretations of Revelation and often makes assertions without sufficient supporting arguments. The author possesses enough authority for readers to trust his perspective; thus, framing the book as a reader’s guide could be misleading. It would be more appropriate to position the book not as a universal guide but rather as a specific historical-symbolic, non-literal interpretation of the Book of Revelation.

The author clearly takes a pastoral approach to reading and interpreting Revelation, and its greatest highlight is the call to respond—to worship God and follow the lamb even unto death.

Spilsbury's background in historical studies provides a unique historical approach that allows the reader to place themselves in the context of the original audience. He draws from the Old Testament in a way the original audience would have understood it, and he then projects this understanding onto the contemporary Christian as a call to respond.

Reading this book will result in no less than a burning heart for the One sitting on the Throne and the slaughtered Lamb. It is fully recommended to those looking for a discipleship approach and to amplify their own viewpoints on Revelation. It will hold the reader accountable and thrust them to live not for this age but for the future. To live through defeat by hoping in the victory to come.

On the other hand, this book is not recommended for readers seeking a comprehensive understanding of the Book of Revelation. Instead, such readers should approach it with caution, recognizing the author's biases and reading it more as a perspective rather than a definitive answer or key to revelation, as the book often claims. The author's bias is evident from the very outset in the foreword: "It's a picture book where all the pictures are theological symbols."

Having a hermeneutical approach placing "all" pictures as theological symbols is definitely a slippery slope. The Bible is a real history book that tells a story that points to God. As such, prophecy Anyone reading the Bible will find patterns and prophecies pointing back to the exodus while at the same time pointing forward to future events. Encompassed with these events, one can find what Dr. Spilsbury masterfully found in Revelation, a deep, heart-burning discipleship message for the contemporary reader.

While this book review is not an extensive theological proposal, looking for a moment at Deuteronomy 29-32, the avid Bible reader can find this pattern. Moses reminds the People of Israel about the past events and re-interprets them in light of the contemporary challenge: take the

promised land. Then Moses prophetically projects the events from exodus and numbers to call the Israelites to a way of living. Putting forth the way of life or the way of death. Essentially prophesying the literal exile and the literal coming back.

The best contribution of Dr. Spilsbury's book is he interprets Revelation almost as what Moses intended Deuteronomy to be: a "letter" for a historical audience intended to provoke a response from its readers. He manages to look back at Old Testament Echoes and patterns to call believers to a way of living. Nevertheless, his own bias prevents him from seeing the plausibility of a literal fulfillment of the events. In the same way, Judges to Kings presents an Israel that does not take warnings of God's word through Moses as literal future events, eventually thrusting them into exile. Those who understood the words of Moses while in exile cried out for the lord and "returned to God and listened to his heart" (Dt 30:2), and God brought them back from every corner of the earth.

A universal reader's guide should take into account both the intended response of the original audience and the contemporary reader while at the same time approaching the events, at least with a sense of possibly being literal events described. Spilsbury tends to focus more on the story than the actual history part, thus preventing himself from seeing a plausible future historical event.

The pure, literal approach presented in the book forces the reader to see the "hidden meaning" behind every single idea. For such things, this type of book presents itself as the key to unlocking the "true" meaning of the symbols and the author as the one who has the real answers. The book then falls as others often do, misrepresenting other postures and viewpoints and alienating other Christian audiences, which could contribute to the debate and thus further the

understanding of the book itself. Instead, it draws from other Christians who similarly view revelation, who praise the book and its approach and further alliance it with others.

Similarly, the use of numeric symbols should be approached with great caution. The author does aim to use the Old Testament patterns to validate the numeric symbolism, but then takes it to a more extreme interpretation. Twenty-four is not literal but symbolic; seven is never literal but symbolic, and 3.5 years is not literal but symbolic. Doing so significantly reduces the Bible to a guessing game.

Yes, the Bible uses numbers to convey a message, but that doesn't mean the actual numbers are symbolic. If that were the case, the reader would fall into the trap of reinterpreting every single number in the Old and New Testament. There were not twelve apostles; they were merely a representation. The Israelites were not in Egypt for 400 years; that was just a symbol. This idea could continue and prove dangerous as it pushes the reader toward the "need" for an interpreter. While Dr. Spilsbury does not present himself as the one with all the answers, the hermeneutical approach he discusses in his book suggests to the lay reader that they will never understand the Bible because it is filled with hidden and difficult-to-interpret symbols. In other words, without the correct reader's guide, they will never understand the message of the "letter".

For such reasons, this book is only recommended for only two audiences. First, for those who already hold an amillennial view and want to structure their thoughts while uncovering a deep understanding of the Old Testament echoes and the call to respond. Secondly, to those who are looking to understand an amillennial-friendly or purely symbolic approach to further their understanding and point their minds to a new viewpoint.

It is not recommended for those trying to understand the Book of Revelation for the first time, as the book presents itself as an “obvious” hermeneutic. This approach, combined with the author’s expertise, might misguide the lay reader.

Conclusion

Dr. Spilsbury presents the book as a guide on how to read Revelation based on a “big picture” approach to the book of Revelation to make it easier for the reader to understand its meaning. While the book does achieve the purpose of giving a big-picture approach, it does not achieve the purpose of making it easier for the reader. Instead, this highly symbolic approach makes it harder for the actual beginner or lay reader as all of the symbols need highly trained understating to be interpreted.

Nevertheless, there is another purpose behind writing the book, which can be found on page 13: To teach what it means to follow the lamb wherever he goes. This is highly achieved as the book leaves the reader with a burning heart and a desire to follow the slaughtered lamb through death to the final victory in the resurrection of the death.

The book definitely draws attention to the Book of Revelation and is a great debate starter. While it should be taken cautiously, anyone not looking to adopt another man’s viewpoints fully should find the book interesting. It does not bring up other viewpoints, so it should be read as a part of a deeper study that also considers futurist, idealist, and historical interpretations.

Dr. Spilsbury brings a historical approach that provokes the reader to respond. As such, whenever this book is read, it should be followed by a deep giving self to the One sitting on The Trone, to the only worthy Lamb, and to the defeat of the Dragon in this age in light of the age to come.